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TUESDAY, DECEMBER 9, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Trump offers \$12B in aid to farmers

Tariff money used after president led trade war on China

By Seung Min Kim, Josh Funk and Didi Tang
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump announced a \$12 billion farm aid package on Monday — a boost to farmers who have struggled to sell their crops while getting hit by rising costs after the president raised tariffs

on China as part of a broader trade war.

He unveiled the plan Monday afternoon at a White House roundtable with Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, Agriculture Secretary Brooke Rollins, lawmakers and farmers who raise cattle and grow corn, cotton, sorghum, soybeans, rice, wheat and potatoes.

“\$12 billion is a lot of money,”

Trump said, adding that the additional aid will help provide certainty for farmers. The money is coming from tariff revenue, he said.

Rollins said another \$1 billion is being held back for specialty crops.

Farmers have backed Trump politically, but his aggressive trade policies and frequently changing tariff rates have come under

increasing scrutiny because of the impact on the agricultural sector and because of broader consumer worries.

The aid is the administration's latest effort to defend Trump's economic stewardship and answer voter angst about rising costs — even as the president has dismissed concerns about affordability as a Democratic “hoax.”

Upward of \$11 billion is set aside for the U.S. Department of Agricul-

ture's Farmer Bridge Assistance program, which the White House says will offer one-time payments to farmers for row crops.

Soybeans and sorghum were hit the hardest by the trade dispute with China because more than half of those crops are exported each year with most of the harvest going to China.

The aid is meant to help farm-

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Registered nurse and care coordinator Elizabeth Julian, right, talks with a patient during a consultation at Thresholds Centers for Mental Wellbeing in Chicago on Nov. 25. Thresholds, which serves people with serious mental health and substance use disorders in Illinois, brought the therapy insurance bill to Rep. Lindsey LaPointe. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Finding better access to behavioral health care

Advocates hope bill will inspire more Ill. therapists to take private health insurance

By Lisa Schencker
Chicago Tribune

Carey Carlock never imagined she'd have so much trouble finding a therapist for her teenage child.

She was a hospital CEO, on the board of a prominent local mental health organization and well connected. Yet the Oak Park mother couldn't locate a therapist

in her community who took her health insurance.

“I found that to just be completely unacceptable,” said Carlock, whose experience led her to change careers and open a new therapy practice in 2021 that now has six locations.

Now, she and others are hoping a recently passed bill will make it easier for people across Illinois to find therapists who take private

insurance.

In recent years, many therapists have stopped taking insurance because of what they describe as low payment rates and administrative hoops that can make it difficult to treat patients — a situation that has left many patients either skipping behavioral health care or paying entirely out of pocket. The newly passed bill aims to address those issues by

setting into law a formula outlining how much insurers must pay therapists for their services.

“This is an affordability bill,” said bill sponsor Rep. Lindsey LaPointe, D-Chicago. “It's not affordable when you pay your monthly premium and then you have to pay \$250 out of pocket for your monthly therapy.”

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Mayor calls budget plan ‘incomplete assignment’

Johnson challenged aldermen to vote on counterproposal

By Alice Yin and Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson delivered a public message Monday to aldermen who are threatening an imminent vote on their own 2026 budget plan: Bring it on.

Speaking at a City Hall news conference, the mayor castigated the slim City Council majority and said that if those 26 aldermen are so confident in their counterproposal to his \$16.6 billion spending plan for next year, then prove it.

“Well, we don't know that they have 26 votes, because nothing's been voted on,” Johnson told reporters. “So I'm saying put it on the board. Let's see. Do people actually want to vote on doubling the garbage fees? They should present that. If City Council members want to double the garbage fees in Englewood, Roseland, Austin, then they should put it on the board and vote.”

Johnson was less forthcoming about whether he would veto the alternate budget plan presented in a letter signed by the aldermen last week, arguing their package is unbalanced because about \$300 million they are counting on to plug next year's \$1.19 billion deficit comes from ideas he said are legally and operationally unfeasible.

The mayor previously vowed to veto any budget approved by aldermen if it hiked property taxes or the garbage fee — and the counterproposal from aldermen would almost double the latter.

“That's just an incomplete assignment,” Johnson said. “I don't want us to overly concentrate on whether something is

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A family looks for answers

The family of a man who died in Cook County Jail over the weekend gathered outside the criminal courthouse Monday morning to call for clarity on the circumstances of his death. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Stock market telling different story about the economy

From jobs to housing to grocery prices, the U.S. economy has been weakening for months. But the stock market is telling a different story. **Business**

Expansion of presidential power

The Supreme Court appeared poised to make it easier for President Donald Trump to fire independent government officials despite laws meant to insulate them from political pressure. **Nation & World**

Illinois has its latest list of endangered species — the end result of many difficult choices



The Karner blue butterfly, which has been placed on the Illinois Endangered Species Protection list, at the Field Museum in Chicago on Nov. 12. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

By Christopher Borrelli
Chicago Tribune

Every five years, a small group of biologists and environmentalists assemble in a large corner office in Springfield with long glass windows. Inside that room, they weigh in on the fate of every animal and plant that exists in Illinois.

They might not see it so starkly — who could wake up every morning with that burden?

And yet that's the job of the nine voting members of the Illinois Endangered Species Protection Board. They gather four times a year and consider and revise the Illinois state list of endangered and threatened animals, insects and plants, which, at the moment, includes 29 birds, 8 mammals, 16 reptiles, 40 fish and 338 plant species. They unveiled their latest five-year update in mid-November. The journey there was full of snoozy, polite meetings but the results will be far-reaching and compli-

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